

UN Human Rights in Occupied Palestinian Territory

Ramallah

8 July 2026

Urgent action needed to protect Dr. Hussam Abu Safiya

UN Human Rights in the Occupied Palestinian Territory calls on the Israeli Government to urgently protect Dr. Hussam Abu Safiya and ensure his safety, dignity, and physical integrity. The Israeli Government must immediately release Dr. Abu Safiya, or promptly charge him with a recognizable criminal offence and grant him a fair trial. In the meantime, he must be urgently transferred to a civilian hospital to ensure that he receives life-saving medical care.

Dr. Abu Safiya, the director of Kamal Adwan Hospital in northern Gaza, has been held in Israeli custody since December 2024 under Israel's Unlawful Combatant Law, without charge or trial. He was arrested at the hospital after refusing to evacuate while treating critical patients.

According to his lawyers, Dr. Abu Safiya appears to be at imminent risk of death. Information available to UN Human Rights - OPT indicates he has been subjected to torture and other ill-treatment, including prolonged solitary confinement, repeated severe assaults resulting in grave injuries, and denial of medical care.

His case raises serious concerns under international humanitarian law and international human rights law, including the prohibition of torture, the right to liberty and security, the right to be brought to justice in a process respecting fair trial guarantees, and the protections afforded to medical personnel during armed conflict.

Despite several appeals to Israeli courts challenging the legality of Dr. Abu Safiya's detention, the courts have so far failed to protect his rights under international law, compounding concerns about the effectiveness of the Israeli judicial safeguards and remedies in relation to Palestinian detainees. Dr. Abu Safiya's lawyers also stated that he was assaulted in detention in retribution for these legal actions.

Thirteen other senior doctors remain in Israeli detention without charge. Around 9,300 Palestinians are currently in Israeli custody, including thousands held arbitrarily without charge or trial. UN Human Rights OPT documentation indicates that torture and ill-treatment of Palestinian detainees is widespread and systematic. At least 91 Palestinians have died in

Israeli detention since 7 October 2023, including several dying due to torture and ill-treatment, according to credible information.

Israel must ensure that its laws governing the detention of Palestinians living under occupation comply with international legal norms and standards, including the prohibition of arbitrary detention and fair trial guarantees, and that its detention officials abide by those standards. All arbitrarily detained Palestinians must be released with immediate effect.

The Israeli Government must immediately and urgently end all forms of torture and ill-treatment against Palestinian detainees. We urge Israel to grant independent medical experts, the International Committee of the Red Cross, and human rights monitors unhindered access to places of detention.

Ends

For additional information on Palestinian detainees, read UN Human Rights relevant reports:

[Detention in the context of the escalation of hostilities in Gaza \(October 2023-June 2024\)](#)

[Overview report on practices and policies affecting human rights in the Occupied Palestinian Territory, including East Jerusalem - 7 October 2023 – 31 May 2025](#)

For more information and media requests, please contact:

Mayy El Sheikh – mayy.elsheikh@un.org

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